

Your Health Card and Your Coverage

What to do before an appointment, what to say at the desk, and letters to send if it goes wrong

Alberta health cards changed on July 2, 2026. Cards issued since that date carry an expiry date. Where a personal health number is printed on a driver's licence or ID card, the health registration runs on the licence date.

Many of us are still holding older paper cards with no expiry date printed on them at all. **Nothing published says what those cards are.** Not that they are invalid. Nobody has said that either. The question has been put to the government in writing and this page will be updated when there is an answer.

In the meantime, this is how to avoid finding out at a desk with a prescription in your hand.

The three things that are settled

Your personal health number is yours for life. It does not change and it is not reissued to anyone else.

What can lapse is your registration, which is the record saying you live here and are covered. That is a separate thing from your number.

Emergency care is never refused. You can still be billed for it if your registration has lapsed, and nothing published says that money is returned, so this is worth staying on top of.

Before an appointment, test or procedure

Confirm your coverage is active **before** you go, not at the desk. It takes one phone call.

Alberta Health Care Insurance Plan

780-427-1432. Toll free within Alberta, dial **310-0000** first, then the number.

Open 8:15 am to 4:30 pm, Monday to Friday. Closed statutory holidays.

It has to be by phone or in person. Not email, because it involves your own health information. Have your health number with you.

Ask two things. Is my coverage currently active. And is there anything I need to do to keep it active. Then write down the date, the time, and the name of the person you spoke to. If they will give you a reference number for the call, take it.

If you are told anything that does not match what you expected, ask them to send it to you in writing. They may say they cannot. Ask anyway, and note that you asked.

If you are questioned at the desk

Take both pieces with you every time. Your health card and your photo identification. That has been the practice for years and it has not changed.

If someone questions your card, keep it short and calm. The person at the desk did not write the policy and cannot change it. Getting their back up makes the next twenty minutes worse and does not get you seen.

What to say

“My card does not have an expiry date printed on it, and my identification is current. Could you check my coverage on your system, please.”

If they say it is expired or not showing:

“Could you tell me what the system is showing, so I can sort it out with Alberta Health. And could I have your name, please.”

What not to do

Do not argue the law at a reception desk. Do not refuse to leave. Do not raise your voice. None of it works and all of it makes you the problem in the room instead of the policy being the problem.

Do not sign anything agreeing to pay without reading it. If you are asked to pay, ask for an itemized invoice with the reason stated, and ask whether they can bill you later once your coverage is confirmed. Many places can.

Write it down before you leave the building

The date and time. The name of the clinic, lab or pharmacy. The name of the person you spoke to. Exactly what you were told. Whether you were billed, and how much.

Do it while you are still in the car park. You will not remember it accurately by the evening, and if this goes anywhere it is the detail that carries it.

If you were billed or turned away, use the letters on the following pages. Send them both. One goes to Alberta Health to sort your coverage out. One goes to the clinic or lab about the bill.

Your details

These fill in the letters on the next two pages.

Your full name

Maximum 80 characters.

Your mailing address

Maximum 160 characters.

Your phone number and email

Maximum 120 characters.

Today's date

Maximum 30 characters.

Do not write your personal health number on this form. Give it by phone or in person only. If a letter needs it, add it by hand to the printed copy after you print it.

What happened

Date it happened

Maximum 30 characters.

Name of the clinic, lab, pharmacy or hospital

Maximum 120 characters.

What you were told, in your own words

Maximum 240 characters.

Amount you were charged, if any

Maximum 40 characters.

Letter one. To Alberta Health, about your coverage

Send this if you were told your coverage is not active, or if you want confirmation in writing. Add your personal health number by hand after printing.

What to send

Alberta Health Care Insurance Plan

PO Box 1360 Station Main, Edmonton, Alberta T5J 2N3

Re: Confirmation of coverage status

I am writing to ask for written confirmation of my Alberta Health Care Insurance Plan coverage status.

On [date it happened] I attended [name of the clinic or lab] and was told [what you were told]. I hold an Alberta Personal Health Card that does not have an expiry date printed on it. My photo identification is current.

Please confirm in writing: (1) whether my coverage is currently active; (2) whether a health card issued before July 2, 2026 that carries no printed expiry date remains valid; (3) if it does not, what I must do to restore or maintain coverage, and by when; and (4) whether I will be reimbursed for [amount you were charged], which I was charged on the date above.

I would be grateful for a written reply. Thank you.

[Your name] · [Your address] · [Your phone and email] · [Today's date]

Question 2 is the one that matters beyond your own file. Nobody has published an answer to it. If enough people ask it in writing, one of the answers that comes back can be shared with everybody.

If you would rather phone than write, that is fine and it is faster. But ask them to send you the answer in writing as well, and note the date you asked.

Letter two. To the clinic, lab or pharmacy, about the bill

Send this if you were charged. Keep it short and do not blame the staff.

What to send

Re: Account for services on [date it happened]

I attended on [date it happened] and was charged [amount you were charged] on the basis that my Alberta Health Care Insurance Plan coverage could not be confirmed.

I hold an Alberta Personal Health Card that carries no printed expiry date, and my photo identification is current. I have written to Alberta Health to confirm my coverage status and I have asked for a written reply.

I am asking you to hold this account without collection activity until Alberta Health confirms my status. If my coverage is confirmed as active for that date, I ask that the charge be reversed and the amount refunded.

Please confirm in writing that the account is on hold. Thank you for your help.

[Your name] · [Your address] · [Your phone and email] · [Today's date]

Why it is worded that way

It asks for a hold rather than demanding a refund, because a hold is something a billing clerk can grant on the spot and a refund usually is not. It gets you out of collections while the real question is being answered somewhere else.

It also does not accuse anybody. The clinic followed what its system told it. The problem is upstream of them, and a letter that says so gets a better result than one that does not.

Tell us what happens

Whatever answer comes back, please send it to the group. Right now nobody has a written answer about undated cards, and one member getting one helps everybody. albertadisabilitybreakdown@outlook.com

Sources. Alberta Health Care Insurance Plan contact details, alberta.ca/ahcip-contact. Health card expiry and revalidation, alberta.ca/health-cards and the integrated card pages. The status of cards issued before July 2, 2026 carrying no printed expiry date could not be located on any government page as at August 2026. This is peer information, not legal or medical advice. Confirm your own coverage with Alberta Health directly.

The Alberta Disability System Breakdown — Advocate

St. Albert, Alberta | August 2026

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